

Quarantine in International Dog and Cat Importation: Epidemiological Basis, Regulatory Models and Critical Failure Points

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Abstract

Objective. To analyze the epidemiological basis of quarantine in international dog and cat importation, identify the three main regulatory models, and describe the technical causes that trigger or prolong its application. **Method.** Comparative review of regulatory frameworks of Australia (DAFF), New Zealand (MPI), European Union (Regulation 576/2013), United Kingdom (DEFRA/APHA) and United States (CDC), with analysis of activation criteria and management protocols. **Results.** Three models are identified: A) routine mandatory quarantine (Australia, New Zealand); B) conditional quarantine for non-compliance (EU, UK); C) no general quarantine but with retention authority (USA-CDC). Most frequent triggers include non-matching microchip, vaccine-serology chronological mismatch, antiparasitic treatments outside the time window, and clinical signs at border inspection. **Conclusion.** Quarantine is preventable in most cases through correct documentary file management and pre-embarkation chronological verification.

Keywords: veterinary quarantine, pet importation, DAFF Australia, MPI New Zealand, CDC, canine rabies, border biosecurity, export documentation

Review of the epidemiological basis of animal quarantine, the three main regulatory models (Australia/NZ, EU/UK, USA), the technical causes that trigger or prolong it, and the current CDC Dog Import Rule framework.

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Section 1 Conceptual framework: quarantine from an epidemiological perspective

1.1 Operational definition: quarantine vs. isolation

The terms quarantine and isolation are often used interchangeably in everyday animal transport language, but they designate distinct epidemiological realities.

Isolation: the separation of an individual with confirmed or highly probable disease from the rest of the susceptible population. Its purpose is to interrupt active transmission of an already identified infectious agent. Isolation is a response measure to a known event.

Quarantine: the restriction of movement of individuals who have been exposed to an infectious agent, or who come from an environment where that agent circulates, but who do not have confirmed disease at the time of the measure. Its purpose is to create an observation period that allows detection of the development of clinical signs before the individual comes into contact with a susceptible population. Quarantine is a precautionary measure against a probable, not confirmed, risk.

In the context of international companion animal movement, destination quarantine has an additional function: it is the period during which health authorities can verify documentation, carry out complementary diagnostic tests, and execute preventive treatments that could not be sufficiently verified at the point of origin.

1.2 Cross-border risk management

Quarantine in companion animal importation does not exist because dogs and cats individually represent an elevated health risk. It exists because mass and continuous

movement of animals across borders creates, in statistical terms, a non-negligible probability of introduction of infectious agents into territories where those agents are not present or have been eradicated.

The central concept is that of population risk threshold: the level of probability of introduction of a pathogen that a State considers acceptable. Countries with greater vulnerable endemic biodiversity, with more exposed agricultural economies, or with a history of costly eradication of diseases such as rabies, set lower thresholds and apply stricter quarantine measures.

1.3 Rabies as the backbone of quarantine systems

Of all the infectious agents whose introduction quarantine systems seek to prevent, rabies occupies a central position. Dog-Mediated Rabies Virus Variant (DMRVV) is the variant that regulatory systems identify as the primary risk in dog importation from certain geographic origins. A country's risk classification is inherently unstable: a territory can be reclassified following an outbreak. For this reason, no reference document can assert the current risk status of a specific country: this information can only be obtained at the official primary source at the time of use.

Section 2 Three regulatory models of quarantine

Model A -- Routine mandatory quarantine: Australia and New Zealand

Australia -- DAFF: the world's strictest system

The Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (DAFF) applies a biosecurity protocol for dog and cat importation that is, by design, the most demanding among developed countries. In the Australian model, Post-Entry Quarantine (PEQ) is a structural component of the import system in force at the date of consultation, regardless of documentation quality or country of origin. It is not a consequence of non-compliance: it is a structural requirement. The difference between a perfect file and one with errors is not

whether the animal passes through quarantine -- it always does -- but the duration of that quarantine and the complexity of the protocol applied.

Australia classifies countries of origin into groups according to their health risk profile. Countries not included in any approved group cannot export animals directly to Australia: the animal must have resided for a minimum established period in an approved country before being able to start the protocol. Verification of which group the country of origin belongs to must be done on the official DAFF website, as the classification can change.

Mickleham -- Approved quarantine facility for dogs and cats in Australia
Post-Entry Quarantine facilities for dogs and cats in Australia operate in Melbourne. Capacity is limited and demand can generate waiting lists that significantly impact arrival schedules. Quarantine facility slot reservation must be managed directly with DAFF with sufficient advance notice. The cost of the quarantine stay is exclusively the owner's responsibility.

New Zealand -- MPI: the strictest protocol in the region

The Ministry for Primary Industries (MPI) applies the Import Health Standard (IHS) for dogs and cats, a protocol that in several respects exceeds Australian requirements. Post-entry quarantine is mandatory and structural, not conditional.

One particularity of the New Zealand system: the microchip must be implanted before the sample for RNATT is taken, not only before rabies vaccination, as per the Import Health Standard in force at the date of consultation. This requirement is a documented source of error in files prepared without verifying the current IHS. Quarantine duration can be extended if clinical signs are detected during the stay, if diagnostic test results are inconclusive, or if antiparasitic treatments were not executed within the exact time windows specified by the IHS.

Model B -- Conditional quarantine for non-compliance: European Union and United Kingdom

European Union -- Regulation (EU) 576/2013, Article 35

The EU framework does not contemplate routine quarantine: an animal that meets all requirements enters without a mandatory observation period. However, Article 35 establishes the measures when an animal arrives without meeting the requirements:

- Re-dispatch to country of origin: the animal is returned, at the owner's expense.
- Isolation under official control: if re-dispatch is not viable, the animal may be held in approved facilities for the time necessary to meet the requirements or until its situation is resolved.
- Euthanasia: as a last resort, when the above options are not viable.

Quarantine in the EU is the consequence of error, not the standard procedure.

United Kingdom -- DEFRA/APHA: up to four months for non-compliance

The Pet Travel Scheme allows entry without quarantine when the requirements of the Animal Health Certificate (AHC) are met. When an animal arrives without meeting them, the authority may impose quarantine of up to four months in approved facilities. The full cost is the owner's responsibility.

Model C -- No general quarantine but retention authority: United States***The CDC Dog Import Rule***

Since August 2024, the current CDC regulations state that all dogs entering the USA must comply: be over six months of age, be microchipped (chip implanted before any rabies vaccine to be relied upon in the process), and complete the CDC Dog Import Form online before arrival. This last condition -- the mandatory digital form for all dogs -- is the most frequently ignored by owners who incorrectly assume that animals from low-risk countries are exempt.

CDC Dog Import Form -- Update 05/02/2026 The CDC Dog Import Form is mandatory for all dogs entering the USA, regardless of country of origin. The system was

updated on 5 February 2026. Receipts issued before that date remain valid until their expiration (6 months). Complete at: cdc.gov/dogimport.

Country-of-origin classification system

The CDC establishes a distinction between countries with high DMRVV risk and countries without that classification. This distinction determines whether a dog can enter with standard documentation or must do so under additional conditions including specific supervision facilities (CDC Animal Care Facility, ACF).

CDC High-risk list -- Critical warning The list of countries classified as high risk for DMRVV is dynamic and can change without notice. Mandatory consultation: cdc.gov/importation/dogs/high-risk-countries.html -- verify on the exact date of travel planning.

Dogs from high-risk countries: CDC facilities (ACF)

For dogs from high-risk countries without a "U.S.-issued" rabies vaccine -- administered in US territory by a US-licensed veterinarian, with a USDA-approved biologic, certified before the dog leaves US soil -- the animal must enter through an airport that has a registered ACF. The number of airports with ACF is limited; route planning must verify that the entry airport has an active ACF at the time of travel.

Airports with CDC Animal Care Facility CDC publishes the updated list at: cdc.gov/importation/dogs/approved-care-facilities.html. Verification that the arrival airport has an active ACF must be done directly at the primary source.

Compliance with federal requirements does not exempt compliance with state-level requirements in the destination state.

Cats: a different federal framework

Domestic cats entering the United States are subject to a different federal regulatory framework. At the federal level, CDC does not require a rabies certificate or form equivalent to the Dog Import Form for cats. However, there are specific requirements of

destination states and transport operators, which can be more stringent. Verification of destination state and operator requirements is mandatory.

Section 3 Technical causes that trigger or prolong quarantine

In all regulatory models there is a common denominator: error at origin. The most frequent causes are:

3.1 Unreadable or non-matching microchip

Inability to read the microchip, or discrepancy between the number in documents and that read on the animal -- even by a single digit -- triggers an "identity not verified" status. The consequence is retention of the animal until identification is resolved.

3.2 Vaccine-serology chronological mismatch

RNATT must be performed from a sample taken at least 30 days after vaccination. A sample taken before produces a non-recognised result, requiring repetition of the entire process. In destinations requiring a post-RNATT waiting period, a chronological error can delay travel by three to six months.

3.3 Antiparasitic treatments outside the time window

Australia, New Zealand and the UK require treatments in precise time windows. A treatment correct in substance but outside the window is not recognised as valid.

3.4 Detection of ectoparasites on arrival

Detection of ticks or ectoparasites on the arrival examination frequently extends quarantine in Australia and New Zealand. Biosecurity at origin -- environmental isolation of the animal in the weeks before travel -- is the most effective preventive measure.

3.5 Documentary inconsistencies

As analysed in the health certificate (Article 10) of this series, internal inconsistencies in the file are the most frequent cause of avoidable quarantine in Models B and C.

3.6 Clinical signs at border inspection

Presence of signs compatible with active infectious disease triggers retention protocols in all systems, regardless of file quality. The pre-travel veterinary examination has among its functions the detection of these situations before the animal is in transit.

Section 4 Clinical impact and animal welfare

4.1 Stress from confinement

Quarantine facilities are not environments designed to maximise individual welfare but to guarantee health control. Prolonged confinement activates stress mechanisms described in Articles 7 and 8 of this series: elevated cortisol, altered circadian rhythms, disturbance of appetite and sleep.

Operational quality varies with each country's regulatory standard and is not uniform globally.

4.2 Previous metabolic state as a resilience factor

An animal in optimal body condition, with vaccinations up to date and without active chronic pathology, tolerates a quarantine period better than an animal in suboptimal condition. Attention to physical condition, progressive adaptation to the carrier and absence of active pathologies reduce the clinical impact of quarantine.

4.3 Health management within facilities

Approved quarantine facilities are subject to official supervision and must meet minimum standards. Prior communication with the facility, detailed identification of the animal and provision of information on specific needs contribute to a quarantine period with less impact.

Section 5 What should not be assumed

5.1 The Australian and New Zealand model is exceptional; most developed destinations (EU, UK, Canada, Japan) do not apply routine quarantine to animals with a complete dossier. Assuming quarantine is universal leads to underestimating the importance of documentation.

5.2 Not every retention is formal quarantine. A certificate with an incorrect field can generate administrative retention of hours, without that constituting quarantine in the technical sense.

5.3 Not every delay is health-related. Delays can have administrative, logistical or operational capacity causes.

5.4 In systems where quarantine is routine, it cannot be avoided; it can be minimised in duration with correct preparation. In systems where it is conditional, it can be prevented almost entirely with a technically correct file.

Section 6 Operational synthesis for veterinarians

The veterinarian is responsible for three things:

- Technical precision of the file: correct microchip-vaccination-RNATT sequence, respected deadlines, verified formats, internal coherence. This is the factor with the greatest impact on the probability of avoidable quarantine.
- Updated verification of destination requirements: at the time each document is issued, not when the relationship with the client was established. Regulations, especially in Model C, can change between planning and travel date.
- Clear communication with the owner: on what quarantine implies in the specific destination, duration, cost and technical factors that the owner can control.

Section 7 Limitations

- Maximum regulatory variability: quarantine is the area of greatest regulatory variability. Direct verification at the official primary source is always mandatory.

- Risk classification dynamism: the CDC list, DAFF groups and MPI categories are living lists, updated following epidemiological changes.
- Facility operational capacity: availability of quarantine facility slots -- especially in Australia -- is an operational variable. Direct management with DAFF is the only mechanism to ascertain real availability.
- State legislation in the USA: federal requirements do not exhaust applicable requirements. Destination state requirements must be verified separately.
- Epidemiological changes: the emergence of outbreaks can immediately modify requirements. Monitoring OIE/WOAH reports is the most relevant surveillance tool.

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<https://www.gov.uk/bring-pet-to-great-britain>
- GOV.UK. Putting your pet into quarantine.
<https://www.gov.uk/guidance/pet-travel-quarantine>
- WOAH/OMSA. World Animal Health Information System (WAHIS).
<https://wahis.woah.org>
- Practical tool

Figure 1. Three regulatory models of quarantine in international pet importation.

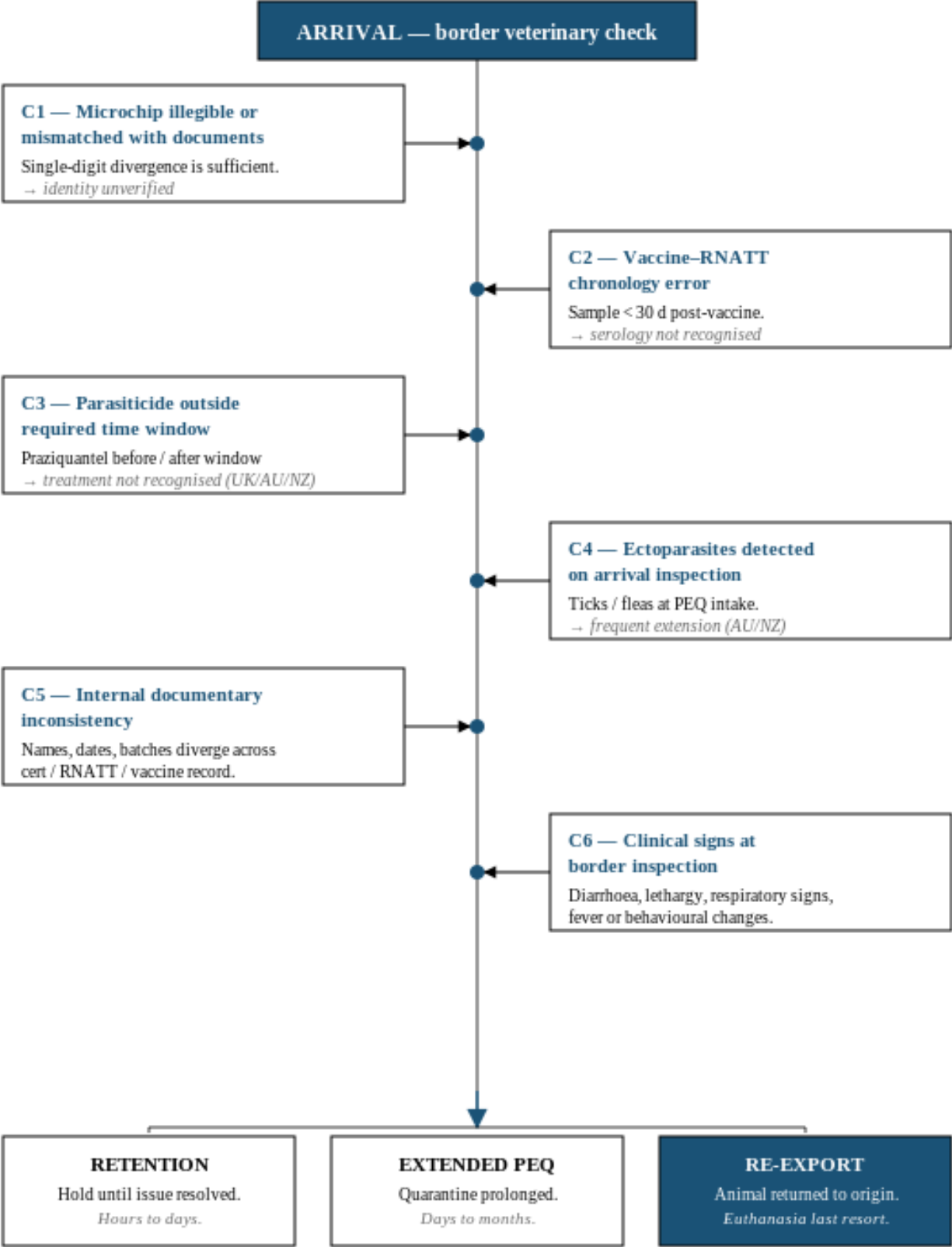
Comparative classification across destination regimes. Verify the current rule with each competent authority before each export.

MODEL A Mandatory PEQ (structural)	MODEL B Conditional (non-compliance)	MODEL C No general PEQ; retention only
Australia (DAFF) · NZ (MPI)	European Union · United Kingdom	United States (CDC)
TRIGGER Every animal, by design. Quarantine is structural, not a sanction.	TRIGGER Triggered only by documentary or technical non-compliance.	TRIGGER Triggered only by border officer or CDC retention authority decision.
LEGAL BASIS DAFF Biosecurity Act 2015; MPI Import Health Standard CATDOG.GEN.	LEGAL BASIS Reg. (EU) 576/2013 art. 35; UK Pet Travel Scheme (APHA / DEFRA).	LEGAL BASIS CDC Dog Import Rule (2024); 42 CFR Part 71; + destination-State rules.
DURATION 10 d (NZ) — 10+ d (AU) <i>extendable on clinical findings</i>	DURATION up to 4 months (UK) <i>until criteria are met</i>	DURATION case-by-case <i>ACF holding until cleared</i>
FACILITY Mickleham (Melbourne); MPI-accredited Auckland; advance booking required.	FACILITY Authorised holding centres (Member-State / APHA- approved kennels).	FACILITY CDC-registered Animal Care Facilities (ACF) at selected airports only.
OUTCOMES Extended PEQ; further tests; repatriation; in extreme cases euthanasia.	OUTCOMES Re-export to origin; supervised isolation until criteria met; euthanasia as last resort.	OUTCOMES ACF holding; denial of entry; re-export. Strict at high-risk DMRVV-country routings.
COST Owner — full PEQ fees.	COST Owner — including re-export.	COST Owner — ACF + handling.

Key takeaway — Models B and C are largely avoidable through a technically correct dossier. Model A cannot be avoided; only its duration can be optimised.
DMRVV = dog-mediated rabies virus variant. PEQ = post-entry quarantine. ACF = CDC Animal Care Facility.

Figure 2. Technical causes that trigger or extend quarantine.

Adapted from Reg. (EU) 576/2013 art. 35, MPI CATDOG.GEN, DAFF PEQ standard and CDC Dog Import Rule. Each cause is independent and



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